domain dominated by institutions that focus on concessional development financing and emergency lending. This concentrated focus allows for systematic comparisons across our empirical analyses and provides a foundation for engaging deeply with the extensive scholarly literature examining IOs in this realm (Stone 2011; Schneider and Tobin 2016; Lipscy 2017; Pratt 2021).

IFIs, such as the World Bank and the IMF, are particularly well suited for analysis because of their high levels of transparency. This openness enables the collection of rich datasets that may not be available for other types of IOs. Additionally, these institutions are among the oldest and most influential actors in the global arena and liberal international order, making them ideal case studies for understanding how IOs operate under pressure and how they respond to populist threats.

Given the centrality of the World Bank and IMF to global development, we provide an overview of their purposes, operations, and vulnerabilities to populist challenges. These institutions are key players in delivering aid, facilitating structural reforms, and responding to financial crises. Their high-profile roles often make them lightning rods for populist criticism, particularly because their conditionality programs and governance structures are frequently framed as emblematic of elite international control. As such, these IOs feature prominently in our analyses, offering a rich lens through which to study the broader implications of populist–IO interactions.

2.6.1 The IMF

The IMF, established in 1944 at the Bretton Woods Conference, stands as one of the pillars of the global financial architecture. With nearly universal membership, the IMF is tasked with ensuring stability in the international monetary system and preventing economic crises. Armed with a lending capacity of up to $1 trillion, the Fund plays a pivotal role in global economic governance.

Headquartered in Washington, DC, the IMF operates with a robust structure that reflects its international reach. Its approximately 2,700 staff members hail from 150 countries, contributing to a diverse and dynamic institutional culture. Governance is anchored by a twenty-four-member Executive Board, which oversees the IMF's daily activities. Each member